

Sony Wants to Get Things Right with Android



Kenchiro Hibi, managing director, Sony India

Sony's smartphone division is struggling to regain its market share in India. The company is known to be far behind its competitors, including Samsung. Now, with a new name—Sony Mobile—and after parting ways with Ericsson, the Japan-based smartphone brand is looking for a change in its fortunes. At the start of 2013, the company introduced its flagship product, Xperia Z, and will be looking to launch more products in the smartphone market. It's never too late to find your way back into the reckoning and Sony is hoping to do so this year. The company is banking big on the Android operating system to work the magic. *S Aadeetya from Open Source For You spoke to Kenchiro Hibi, managing director, Sony India, about the company's plans with Android. Here are some excerpts:*

Q: At the moment there are many operating platforms vying for space in the smartphone segment. Which one does Sony Mobile prioritise?

Sony's first preference has always been Android, which is why you have seen the company launching Xperia smartphones at regular intervals. That said, we are open to

all the mobility platforms available in the market right now including Windows. But from Sony's point of view, it is important for us to establish ourselves within the Android market first and then we might look at other options.

Q: You talked about Windows being an option for you. What is stopping you from entering the Windows Phone arena, as of now?

As I just mentioned, Sony is looking at all the options, including Windows Phone. But the market for Windows Phone is yet to pick up. We have seen majors like Nokia and HTC involve themselves in the Windows ecosystem, but they did not do as well as their Android counterparts in the market. Apart from that, not many vendors have opened up to Windows, probably because of its immature eco-system. We'll watch the developments before we actually move on to the Windows platform.

Q: What about the Firefox OS from Mozilla, which is expected to make its way into the market by the end of this year?

Firefox is a platform that Sony is interested in being a part of. We recently had a tele-conference discussing the possibility of working on a device that runs on the Firefox mobile OS. However, the platform is still in its developmental stage, which is why it won't be possible for the company to comment on something officially. We are not working on any Sony smartphone for Firefox, as of now. If the Firefox OS is able to succeed in the market and offer a premium user-experience, then we would engage with the company more deeply.

Q: Sony has its Playstation OS, which is hugely popular. Do you think this platform could be integrated into smartphones, just like Samsung's Bada OS and Tizen, which will be launched in the coming months?

Yes, Sony has the Playstation OS but then, there are a lot of other platforms like Windows Phone and Firefox as well. Right now, Sony is completely focused on getting things right with Android and after that we will test the other platforms. Sony has not really thought much about having its own operating system, but maybe we could work on something in the near future.

Q: According to some recent reports, Sony is aiming for the third spot in terms of market position in the smartphone segment. Any particular reason for that?

We cannot aim for the sky from Day One. Our performance over